

Twentieth-century political philosophy



US and Soviet tanks face off against each other in post-war Berlin at the beginning of the Cold War that shaped much of political philosophy in the 20th century.

The 20th century saw unprecedented changes in the world's political make-up. Around a third of the world adopted some form of Marxist-inspired regime, while old European colonial empires shrank. Mid-century, the rise of tyrannical fascism and Nazism sparked the Second World War, followed by the Cold War between Eastern communism and Western capitalism. Political philosophy reacted in various ways to these changes, suggesting new models to replace the failing systems. The harsh reality of communist regimes prompted a reappraisal of Marx's theories in the 1930s, and again after the collapse of the Soviet Union in the 1990s. In the US, philosophers concentrated on notions of democracy, justice and the role of government,

ideas that were also of importance to the many states seeking and gaining independence from colonial rule. In the comparatively peaceful period following 1945, issues of civil rights, including race and gender, and pressing environmental problems also played a significant role in shaping modern political philosophy.